The Ogham Alphabet

Ogham is an ancient alphabet that appeared in Ireland at least 1,600 years ago. It was used to inscribe Primitive Irish onto stone monuments. Ogham is written from bottom to top along a center line or "stem". Primitive Irish did not have several sounds that English has so, among the consonants, there is no letter for J (as in jam), K, V, W, Y, P, or the two distinct English sounds that are spelled with the TH digraph. Among the vowels, *many* substitutions are necessary as Primitive Irish had a very different vowel inventory than modern English. Visit your name in Ogham and the Ogham transliterator to transliterate your own name into Ogham and see what substitutions it makes.

The word *ogham* refers only to the form of the letters, while the letters themselves are known collectively as the *Beith-luis-nin* , these are the first three names of the letters in the ogham alphabet, in the same manner as the word *alphabet* derives from the first two names of the letters *alpha* and *beta* .

B Group – Right side strokes – *Aicme Beithe*

Ogham	Letter	Name
	B	beith
	L	luis
	V/F	fearn
	S	sail
	N	níon

H Group – Left side strokes – *Aicme hÚatha*

Ogham	Letter	Name
	H	uath
	D	dair
	T	tinne
	C	coll
	K	ceirt

M Group – Across strokes – *Aicme Muine*

Ogham	Letter	Name
ᚋ	M	muin
ᚌ	G	gort
ᚍ	NG	nGéadal
ᚎ	Z	straif
ᚏ	R	ruis

A Group – Notches (vowels) – *Aicme Ailme*

Ogham	Letter	Name
ᚐ	A	ailm
ᚑ	O	onn
ᚒ	U	úr
ᚓ	E	eadhadh
ᚔ	I	iodhadh

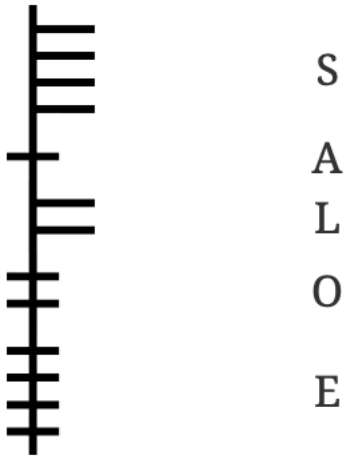


Figure 1: *eolas*, in Modern Irish, means ‘knowledge’ or ‘information’